

# Empowering Foster Youth: A Workforce Media Project Proposal

## 1. Background

Deadline: 05/15/2025 04:00 PM  
Program Overview  
Program Title: Empowering Foster Youth: A Workforce Media Project  
Duration (in months): 12  
CHANGE Sectors: 1C Community Centered Economy  
Program Location: Oahu  
Age: 14 to 17, 18 to 24  
Gender: All  
Fiscal Sponsor: No  
Program Information  
Organization Description: In 1989, 'Olelo Community Media became Oahu's non-profit community Public, Education, and Government (PEG) access provider created to empower the voice of the community.

Since then, 'Olelo has evolved and expanded to better serve the diversity of our unique island community. Today, when you view any one of 'Olelo's four cable channels, VOD channels, or online channels, you will find unique and local stories from hundreds of dedicated community producers about our island, our people, the many cultures we share, and the issues we face. From a small one-room office in the late 80s, we now have six media centers around the island, each designed to enable you to tell the stories that matter to you.

Whether your goal is to educate, entertain, or inform, 'Olelo is here to empower you to share your stories using the powerful medium of video. 'Olelo provides access to media training, production facilities, and air time on our cable and online outlets to deliver non-commercial programming - without the costs and constraints of traditional television. Guided by our core values of teamwork, integrity, and aloha, we facilitate meaningful dialogue and increased participation in civic life.

Our neighborhood-based Community Media Centers (CMCs) provide convenient access to our services across Oahu. Each MSC is committed to providing all members of the community an accessible and welcoming environment to create and distribute media. Whether you live on the Waianae Coast, North Shore, Windward side or East Honolulu there is a media center near you. 'Olelo also provides innovative technology, including state-of-the-art video equipment, studios, and facilities.

We broadcast community programming on high quality distribution equipment not only on cable providers here on Oahu, but also 24/7 on the Internet worldwide. We encourage you to share your stories, your message, and engage with the diverse group of individuals who call Oahu our home. It is through sharing of our local stories that we connect ourselves with those around the island and around the world. When our voice thrives, so does our community.  
Problem or Opportunity: In 2023, Hawaii reported 1,959 children in the foster care system.

## 2. Program Design

While recent statistics indicate a significant decrease over the last 20 years, it negates the pressing needs of supporting current youth in care, particularly for those aging out of the foster care system. Youth who "age out" are often not reunified with family or adopted and instead left to secure housing, employment and essential health care services independently with limited guidance or resources accessible or known to them.

Statistically, foster youth struggle to achieve independence for a plethora of reasons that may be compounded through trauma, abuse, neglect, some directly attributed to foster care such as multiple placements. As a result, when compared to non-foster youth, foster youth that age out of the foster care system struggle to attain higher education, employment and meet basic needs while also representing

higher rates of health and/or mental health conditions.

In the same year (2023), foster children were highlighted in the news as the State of Hawai'i Department of Human Services reported instances where foster youth had to sleep in hotels or government offices due to a lack of available placements, appropriate resource caregivers, emergency shelters for troubled youth and residential mental health centers. This situation highlights the vulnerability of youth in foster care, and the urgent need for programs that provide stability, skill development, and pathways to independence.

The Empowering Foster Youth project directly addresses this gap by offering foster youth the tools to build a future beyond the foster care system. By engaging them in media production, the program not only imparts technical skills but also fosters a sense of purpose and belonging. Research indicates that youth who participate in structured programs that build skills and provide mentorship are more likely to achieve positive outcomes, including stable employment and housing.

Central to this project is development of a digital resource guide that will serve as a self-advocacy tool and connector for other foster youth, particularly those aging out of care, to inform them of necessary benefits, processes, systems and opportunities. This initiative will directly benefit 24 foster youth aged 16-24 on Oahu, providing them with hands-on experience in digital media production, including video editing and storytelling; workforce readiness training, encompassing customer service skills, resume development, and job placement support; and most importantly a platform to share their stories, fostering a sense of agency and community.

### **3. Partners and Roles**

By equipping these young individuals with both technical and soft skills, the project aims to enhance their employability and self-sufficiency, thereby addressing the critical needs of this vulnerable population while simultaneously creating a necessary tool for future youth. Program Activities Address the unique needs of foster children or of their caregivers; and, empower foster children to participate in the decisions affecting their lives. The Empowering Foster Youth project places high regard on the development of mentor-mentee relationships through small cohorts (6 youth) and hands-on training.

MENTOR, a strong grassroots advocate to expand youth mentorship opportunities, recognizes the importance of mentors in youth development and networking. Their published research indicates youth with a mentor have increased feelings of support that enhances well-being and mental health, are more likely to feel a sense of belonging, and feel supported with school/education. Olelo's 1:6 cohort size allows for strong, valuable and meaningful relationship building in which youth can expect to develop independence while gaining professional skills.

Our cohort will span 12 months with the initial 3 months for recruiting, 3 months of training, 3 months of on-the-job training, and 3 months of career counseling and job placement. During the last 90-days, all 24 youth will participate in the development and production of a digital media resource guide. During the initial 90 days (Phase 1), participants acquire customer service and office skill training to effectively navigate workflows with tools such as Outlook, TEAMS, Planner and Media Center Manager, among others.

Phase 1 incorporates varying degrees of role-playing exercises that build to playing in active role in Olelo operations (directly supervised) to gain professional experience and introduces youth to the media production process as youth shadow on an Community Olelo Production. In the 90 days that follow (Phase 2), responsibilities will gradually increase and youth directly engage with customers under

supervision and attend team meetings as contributing members to discussion.

Youth are assigned independent workloads and receive performance evaluations as they prepare to develop a media product. In the last 6 months (Phase 3) youth assume full-responsibility of their work and become integrated as mentors to newer participants or youth that have not yet completed earlier phases. Youth will work on media development and collaborate through all production phases to storyboard, design and produce a digital resource guide that highlight services, supports and opportunities for youth in foster care, with special emphasis on those aging out of care. The program design is what we consider "full circle".

#### **4. Timeline**

The Urban Institute reported in 2021 that youth with history of foster care, experience a lack of access to familial relationships that guide professional development and social networks that increase social capital when finding employment or higher education opportunities. The Empowering Foster Youth program design is progressive in both hard- and soft-skill development but also allows youth to mature into mentorship roles that applies effective communication, problem-solving, critical thinking and collaboration capabilities.

As such, this design sustainably fills an essential professional gap many youth in foster care encounter. These networks help build an understanding of how to succeed at work and effectively navigate the challenges of adulthood. Probability of success with the program is enhanced with career support services and access to concrete resources for eligible participants through the collaboration with OWDB. Expected Results The Empowering Foster Youth: A Workforce Media Project is designed for 24 individual youth aged 16-24 (not gender specific) that have a connection to the foster care system.

The project replicates on a smaller and integrated scale, adjusted for youth, Olelo's current training and volunteer programs. Youth participate in cohorts with a 1:6 ratio for training and OJT to learn, develop and apply hard- and soft-skills as they gain professional experiences and develop a professional network. Consistent with current programs at Olelo, participation is tracked for each event through attendance records. Over a 12 month period, Olelo will recruit, train, develop a digital resource guide and support career transition for each individual youth.

Consistent with the WIOA framework, we anticipate 100% of the participants will actualize a Measurable Skill Gain (MSG). An MSG is defined as a measurable - quantitative or qualitative - improvement in skill, knowledge or ability. The incremental phase design allows Olelo to adequately track progression and levels of attainment systematically and consistently across all participants. A performance evaluation also tracks individual success and allows for necessary adjustments or engagement of auxiliary and augmented resources internally accessible (such as advanced training opportunities for conflict-resolution) as well as accessible through the partnership with OWDB (such as a supplied bus pass for more reliable transportation).

The performance evaluation will include discussion with each youth and make note of their independent assessments regarding their progression in their technical and/or occupational skills. At the conclusion of training, each youth will additionally receive a certificate of completion. Understanding normal attrition rates and unique factors associated with foster placement that can affect consistency and completion such as multiple placements, family reunification, necessitated employment, or encountering other social barriers, among others.

## 5. Outcomes and Evaluation

Olelo anticipates 75% reach completion and 70% of participants achieving job placement or post-secondary enrollment within 12-months of the program conclusion. Depending on the rate of attrition, cohorts may be consolidated to ensure proper execution of role-playing exercises and mentorship opportunities. Participants may achieve job placement even without completing the entire program. Regardless of completion of training or participation in the digital resource development, participants will all have access to career counseling resources that support development of a resume and aids in job searches.

All participants that enter Phase 3 of the training will be given a hard-drive to establish a digital portfolio for their professional use and be credited in the final digital resource guide. The resource guide and all digital media will have shared branding and publication rights with the youth, Olelo Community Media, O'ahu Workforce Development Board, and the Victoria S. and Bradley L. Geist Foundation. Multi-Year Request At present, this is designed as a one-year initiative but may develop into a multi-year program conditioned on the Program's Success and needs to sustain any digital media products.

Any future funding would focus on resource expansion, wider-broadcasting and establishment of future cohorts for similar training and professional skill development but would require a different production deliverable. No consultants will be used or paid for through funding of this initiative. Budget Total Program Budget: \$177,600.00 Amount Requested: \$50,000.00 Budget Olelo\_Budget\_Narrative.pdf 187.2 KB - 05/14/2025 9:40 PM Olelo\_Empowering\_Foster\_Children.pdf 90.4 KB - 05/14/2025 9:34 PM Total Files: 2 Supporting Documents & Certification Supporting Documents Olelo\_Project\_Tracking\_Matrix.pdf 149.8 KB - 05/14/2025 9:43 PM Total Files: 1 Upload Letter: 10667\_-\_Olelo\_Community\_TV\_CC\_Ltr.pdf 251.8 KB - 07/31/2025 9:53 AM Total Files: 1 Olelo Community Media is well-versed in workforce development initiatives and youth projects and focused on innovative media.

We have leveraged our unique background and on-going efforts to develop a comprehensive and new project we have titled Empowering Foster Youth: A Workforce Media Project. This project combines the concept of a digital resource guide with current training initiatives and plans. Although the foster care resource guide was previously created, it was not able to come to fruition due to a lack of funding; the funding barrier was the catalyst for our pursuit of the Victoria S. and Bradley L.

Geist Foundation: Supporting Foster Children and their Caregivers Funding Opportunity. We do believe there is value in the production of such a guide but without adequate, appropriate funding, we would otherwise be unable to commit the necessary resources to ensure proper execution. To provide the full scope of our request, which includes all phases of delivery from recruitment, training, professional experiences and digital development for 24 youth, we are requesting a total of \$50,000.00 for funding.

## 6. Sustainability

We base our funding request off of our current initiatives that includes components of skills training and on-the-job training and calculate cost per cohort, each cohort comprised of 6 students. \$30,000.00 of requested funds are directly for training. Training will be delivered across 4 cohorts comprised of 6 youth for a total of 24 youth served. Training modules are broken down for a cost of \$7,500 per cohort as follows: \$2,375.00 - Office & Soft Skill Development \$2,500.00 - Customer Service Training - includes Appointment Management and front-of-office experience \$2,625.00 - Media Engagements (single & multi-camera use); includes student hard-drive to store media for individual portfolio production Based on Olelo's production cost to include studio setup, animation design, equipment usage, etc. \$10,000 will be

needed for the video production of a digital resource guide for foster youth that will have shared media and publication rights.

The remaining \$10,000 of the request will be for recruitment, participant screening/tracking and auxiliary services including services to those that eligible under WIOA Guidelines, for example youth in households that exceed incomelimits or in excess of the in-school participation ratios. Within the limitation of WIOA funding, eligible youth may be supported with purchase of a uniform, bus passes, and/or other work essential items that will not utilize funding from the Geist Foundation.

All youth will have access to career services. At this time, other prospective funding sources have not been identified or confirmed. Future funds from the U.S. Department of Labor are being assessed for project alignment and feasibility, but any such funding would affect the future lifecycles of this project as the current timing nears the federal end of fiscal. If all anticipated funding is not received, Olelo Community Media is prepared to scale back services by reducing cohorts and/or specific training components; however, this in turn will affect performance outcomes and total number of participants served directly through the initiative. Project/Program Budget Form Requesting Organization Name: Olelo Community Television In Column A, describe the expenses for your project.

In Column B, indicate the amount you are requesting from HCF. In Column C, indicate any additional amounts that will support that expense. Column D will automatically sum Columns B and C. At the bottom of the table, each column will automatically sum. Please note that matching funds are encouraged. ABCD Project Expense: HCF request: Other funding source/ In-kind contribution: Total Cost: 1. Customer Service Training \$10,000.00 \$10,000.00 2.

Office & Soft Skill Development \$10,000.00 \$10,000.00 3. Media Production Training \$10,000.00 \$10,000.00 4. Media Production Equipment \$64,000.00 \$64,000.00 5. Editing Equipment \$27,600.00 \$27,600.00 6. Digital Resource Guide for Foster Youth \$10,000.00 \$10,000.00 7. Resource Guide Production Crew \$36,000.00 \$36,000.00 8. OWDB Recruitment, Participant Screening/Tracking \$10,000.00 \$10,000.00 Total for each column: \$50,000.00 \$127,600.00 \$177,600.00 Please identify the sources of funding for your project.

## 7. Risks

Indicate the total amount of support from each source and if the source is secured, pending, or in-kind. At the end of the table, total the amount. This total should match the total cost of your project (Column D in the above table). List all types of support Amount (list value of volunteer/donated services) Indicate if source is secured, pending, or in-kind 1. HCF Geist CC\_2025\_00010667 Fund \$50,000.00 Pending 2. \$Please Select Status 3. \$Please Select Status 4. \$Please Select Status 5. \$Please Select Status Total: \$50,000.00 Organization Name: Project Title: Project Tracking Matrix Program Outputs Proposed Results for Program Year Actual Results for Program Year % of Goal Achieved Measurement of Results # Ex.

Satisfaction of clients in program Ex. 75% of participants will show satisfaction in the program Ex. 89% 119% Ex. Surveys (Pre & Post) 1 Measurable Skill Gained (a quantitative or qualitative improvement in skill, knowledge or ability). 100% of participants will have at least one MSG 2 Completion of all phases of training 75% of participants will complete all training phases of the project 3 Achieve job-placement or post-secondary education within 12 months of completion 70% of participants will have employment or post-secondary education within 12 months of the project 4 Receive career planning services 100% of participants will receive career planning services and complete a resume 5 Development of a digital resource guide Completion of one (1) digital

|                                             |                                     |                                               |
|---------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|
| resourceguide678910111213141516171819202122 | Explanation of Variance/Other Notes | Goal was exceeded due to stafing improvements |
|---------------------------------------------|-------------------------------------|-----------------------------------------------|

# Appendix A. Budget Summary

| Line item        | FY2026    | FY2027    | Owner              |
|------------------|-----------|-----------|--------------------|
| Media production | \$84,000  | \$91,500  | Program lead       |
| Youth stipends   | \$36,000  | \$40,000  | Finance            |
| Equipment        | \$22,400  | \$6,000   | Operations         |
| Evaluation       | \$12,000  | \$12,000  | External evaluator |
| Total            | \$154,400 | \$149,500 |                    |

Table A.1 shows the two-year budget. Equipment spend front-loads in FY2026 because cameras and editing workstations are purchased once.